

The Blossom Mountains of Yamato



The blossom mountains of Yamato rise in soft green folds above terraced rice fields and little villages strung with paper lanterns, where cherry trees drop their petals on the wind and red torii gates mark the quiet shrines. Mist drifts among the bamboo, the moon lays a silver path on the river, and the hills are full of gentle spirits: a riddling fox, shy fireflies who light the lanterns, a jolly trickster tanuki, stone guardian dogs, and a great old river dragon who brings the rains. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is patient, thinks things through, and is kind to every living thing. The grandest deeds are done with wisdom and courage and a gentle heart, and even a fearsome guardian, met with a calm and friendly word, often turns out kinder than it looks.



Who's Who and What's What

Places

The Lantern Village - A little village of wooden houses and terraced rice fields, the heroes' home, strung with paper lanterns and bright with festivals through the year.

The Moonlit Bridge - An arched wooden bridge over the river, silver in the moonlight. It carries safely those who cross it gently, with a calm and honest heart.

The Red Torii Gate - A tall vermilion shrine gate on the mountain path, watched over by two stone guardian lion-dogs who let pass those who answer kindly and think with a cool head.

The Silver River - The wide river that waters the rice fields of the valley. When the river dragon sleeps too long, it runs low and the fields grow thirsty.

The Whispering Bamboo Grove - A cool green grove of tall bamboo above the village, where the stalks click and whisper in the wind and a riddling fox likes to play.

Characters

Amaterasu the Sun-Kami - The warm goddess of the sun, who watches over the mountains and smiles on heroes that win by thinking and caring rather than by force.

Granny Yuki the Tale-Keeper - The kind old tale-keeper of the Lantern Village, who knows every story of the mountains and sends the heroes out with a warm word and a small gift.

Creatures



Kon the Fox - A friendly fox spirit of the bamboo grove who loves riddles and clever games, and hands out helpful hints to travellers he likes.

Pon the Tanuki - A jolly, round raccoon-dog who loves games and surprises. He means well, but his happy bustling sometimes turns everything upside down by mistake.

The Firefly Spirits - Gentle, shy spirits of light who nestle inside the paper lanterns and make them glow. When they feel safe and happy, the whole village shines.



The Gentle River Dragon - A great old dragon of the Silver River whose stirring brings the rains. He looks mighty, but he is gentle and a little lonely, and he wakes not to a loud voice but to a soft bell and a kind song.

The Guardian Lion-Dogs - A pair of stone lion-dogs who guard the red torii gate. They look fierce but are fair and kind, and they open the way for those who answer a riddle with a cool head.

Items

The Little Bell - A small bronze bell with a clear, gentle ring. Its sound calms worried hearts and can wake a sleeping friend ever so softly.

The Paper Lantern - A round paper lantern on a little handle. When a friendly firefly spirit nestles inside, it glows warm and lights the way in the dark.

The Red Thread - A length of bright red thread. Tie one end where you start and you can always find your way back, and some say it gently ties friends together too.

The Rice Cake - A soft, sweet rice cake. Shared with a shy or lonely spirit, it can turn a worried face into a friend.

Words to Know

Courage - A steady heart in a quiet, scary moment. Courage is not being unafraid; it is being kind and clever even when you are afraid.

Kindness - Care for every living thing, from a shy firefly to a great dragon. The greatest heroes of the mountains are the ones who are gentle, share, and help.

Wisdom - A calm mind and a thoughtful question. In these mountains, wisdom solves a riddle that strength never could.

Idea Bank: The Blossom Mountains of Yamato

Improv prompts for the grown-up. When the children want to try something the page did not plan for, reach in here. Nothing is a wrong answer; every idea bends toward calm, cleverness, and nobody losing.

If the heroes are stuck

- Kon the Fox trots out of the bamboo, asks a tiny riddle whose answer is the next clue, then winks and slips away.
- A breeze carries a single cherry petal that drifts to land on the right path.
- Granny Yuki's voice floats up the valley with the first line of an old tale that holds a hint.
- Let the heroes spend an energy star to "remember a saying Grandmother taught them".

Friendly faces to drop in

- A patient crane standing in the rice field who will share the way for a kind bow.
- A round, jolly tanuki who knows a shortcut but keeps getting distracted.
- A tiny tea-kettle spirit who has lost its lid and could use a hand.
- A sleepy cat curled on a warm step who only wants someone to sit a while.

Gentle troubles to solve

- A bridge that will only hold those who cross it slowly and gently.
- A row of paper lanterns to light in the right order so the path glows.
- A muddle of festival stalls to sort back into place.
- A line of stepping stones across the river to read and cross in turn.

Ways to win that are not winning

- Make the stone lion-dogs smile instead of out-arguing them.
- Trade a rice cake for a story instead of for the way through.
- Ring the little bell softly until a sleeping friend stirs, rather than shouting.
- Leave the place calmer and kinder than you found it.

Yamato flavour to sprinkle

- Cherry blossom on the breeze, the click of bamboo, the smell of warm rice.
- Paper lanterns glowing along a path, a red torii gate, a silver moon on the river.
- The hush of a misty mountain, the soft ring of a temple bell, a folded paper crane.

Stories in this world

The Firefly Lanterns (young). Tonight is the summer Lantern Festival in the Lantern Village.

The River Dragon's Long Sleep (older). The Silver River is running low.

The Tanuki's Tidy-Up (young). It is festival day in the Lantern Village.

Wits and Wonder

World Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.